am more confident than ever that under your leadership NELCO will in time be one of the Companies in the Tata Group of which we shall be very proud.'

But despite Ratan's determined efforts, he could not implement all his plans for the company. The most significant of them was for NELCO to start manufacturing computers—it was some four years before India's largest computer manufacturing company HCL produced its first personal computers in 1978.

While TCS was making strides in software development, his plan was to get NELCO to start the hardware side of the business, but the restrictive controls of the Licence Raj killed his proposal. Exasperated at the glacial speed of the government in according approvals, Ratan wrote to JRD: 'The "ultra-efficient" Department of Electronics considered our application and granted us a Letter of Intent in September 1979—over five years after our application!'

In spite of the many challenges, Ratan gave the company a new focus and increased its turnover from Rs 3.3 crore in 1971 to nearly Rs 207 crore in 1992, an increase of over sixty-two times in slightly over twenty years. As S.K. Mukherjee, the MD of NELCO in 1990, and Raju Bhinge, who spent over a decade in the company, said, Ratan's 'main contribution' was to give NELCO 'the sense of direction it sorely needed'. There is little doubt that if it were not for Ratan, the company would have gone into liquidation.

Ratan surprised many when, under his leadership, NELCO expanded its product base and managed to survive in a competitive market. His critics, however, were loath to acknowledge his achievement. As Ratan explained to a business newspaper later: 'It's unfair. No one wanted to see that NELCO did become profitable, that it went from a 2 per cent market share to a 25 per cent market share. Those issues have been forgotten.' He also acknowledged that his tenure with NELCO gave him the opportunity to test his skills in a competitive market.

In 1977, NELCO suffered a lockout for seven months. Its workers had made some unreasonable demands. Ratan did not relent. He showed his 'mettle by handling the strike. When it happened, he stood firm. When push comes to shove, he will hold the ground and do what he thinks is right,' comments Soonawala. Paradoxically, the tough stance that Ratan took was a cause of pain for him. It went against his deep sense of compassion.